CORE-07 | Therapist guide only

Planning an experiment to explore an expectation

Core 07: a specific question, an agreed experiment and information to examine together.

Purpose of this unit

Learn about an expectation through an experiment chosen with the client after assessing suitability. Focus on information about the expectation, not activity alone or proving the client wrong.

Before planning

Open with SES-S01 and explore whether the client wants to examine a question. Consent, ability, context and boundaries must be clear. These forms are neither an exposure protocol nor a substitute for appropriate training.

Planning steps

1. Express a specific expectation and its context in the client's words.
2. Choose a suitable action that can provide information about the question.
3. Specify beforehand what can be seen or heard and what may remain inconclusive.
4. Agree on scope, conditions, preparation and support, including others' consent where relevant.
5. Set boundaries, options to change or stop and a review time. Close with SES-S02.

Limits of use

Exclude real danger and assess limitations and consequences. Do not plan harm, privacy violations or medical treatment changes to test an expectation. If no suitable test exists, keep the question for other work.

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Turning a prediction into observable information

These fictional examples are everyday and limited. They are not a plan to follow without individual adaptation.

Group	A question and possible example to explore
Children	Expectation: I will need help with every part of a familiar task. Choose a small part with the child and notice when help is requested, without withholding help or making it a success test.
Adolescents	Expectation: I will not produce any draft ideas. Agree on a brief attempt to list ideas and record what emerged and what interfered. Publishing or submitting the result is not required.
Adults	Expectation: I cannot start organizing a task without finishing it all. Choose a defined stage and examine what was done and what affected stopping at the agreed time.
Older adults	Expectation: I will need repeated explanations at every stage of my chosen activity. Choose a familiar part, keep help available and record what was understood with what support. Do not infer overall ability.

Observation and interpretation

Define describable information, not assumptions about another person's thoughts. Note in advance any dependence on others or external conditions. One outcome is not proof for all situations.

Confirmation is information too

The experiment may support, qualify or leave the expectation open. Do not change the question afterwards to manufacture disconfirmation. Learn from the actual conditions and support too.

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Adaptation, choice and the option to stop

Plan the task only within appropriate training and professional scope.

Group	Practical adaptation
Children	Use one question, a concrete experience, simple language and a clear adult role. Keep help available and check the child understands and can express a wish to change or stop.
Adolescents	Offer choice of question and how much information to disclose. Do not use peer pressure, surprise or unagreed publication of content.
Adults	Explore resources, limitations, responsibilities and roles. Distinguish agreement in principle from ability to act under the specified conditions.
Older adults	Use adult language, desired scope and accessible methods. Record chosen support as part of the conditions without assuming impaired ability.

A clear plan for adjustments

Specify what would prompt reducing, postponing or stopping and how to return to the therapist. Changes in willingness or conditions require reassessment. Do not direct forced continuation to achieve an outcome.

No automatic expansion

The learning sheet concerns the agreed experiment. It does not authorize increasing scope, reducing necessary help or choosing another activity without joint review.

When to choose another tool

If the prediction cannot be suitably tested, safety needs assessment or burden prevents learning, move to assessment or other appropriate work.

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Learning from the outcome before drawing conclusions

CORE-07-P separates what was planned, what was done and what can be concluded.

Joint review

Describe the attempt and outcome, compare with the expectation and explore other influences. Leave missing information missing. If not attempted, assess barriers and suitability rather than infer the client's ability or willingness.

A cautious conclusion

State what was learned in this case and what remains open. Do not generalize from one result; an alternative thought is optional. Choose next steps separately after reviewing information and preferences.

Connecting to next steps

Core 8 reviews insights and tools to retain and needs that remain. Progressing through units does not establish that the expectation is resolved or treatment is complete.

Content status

Original drafts without validation or professional approval. Review every age adaptation and document content and rights reviews before distribution.

General sources for further reading

Beck Institute: Behavioral Experiments in Cognitive Therapy
Background on distinguishing an activity from testing an expectation.
https://beckinstitute.org/blog/behavioral-experiments-in-cognitive-therapy/

Beck Institute: Selecting Techniques in CBT
Background on selecting intervention according to formulation and preferences.
https://beckinstitute.org/blog/selecting-techniques-in-cbt/

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